

National Biosecurity Week 2026 - Why Animal Biosecurity Matters: Video description and transcript

Introduction

This is the accessible text transcript of one person filmed interview-style discussing National Biosecurity Week and the importance of animal biosecurity and a One Health approach, created for an external public audience.

Transcript

[Video begins]

Speaker: Dr Brant Smith, First Assistant Secretary, Biosecurity Animal Office

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Hi, I'm Dr Brant Smith.

I'm a veterinarian and I'm also the head of the Animal Biosecurity Division in the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry.

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This National Biosecurity Week, I want everyone to understand how important animal biosecurity is, not just for our animal health, but for the safety of our environment, our economy, food supply and communities into the future, no matter where we live.

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Animal biosecurity helps protect Australia, not just with animals, but also with people and with the environment.

And when we think of animal health, it's not just about livestock.

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It's also about our pets, our assistance animals, it's about aquatic animals and a whole range of things to keep our communities safe.

We take what's called a One Health approach.

One Health just means environment, human health and animal health and how that comes together, not just for ourselves but for everybody in our community.

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Australia has a very strong biosecurity system, but we do have a lot of trade.

We have a lot of movements of people and animal products right across the world.

So global trade is important.

Climate change is important, and we're seeing the spread of pests and diseases right across not just our country, but the world.

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What's really important is that we all have a role to play.

Did you know that last year, our detector dogs at the border detected 40,000 items of significance? And that's really important because just one of those can create disease or an outbreak.

So you can have a really important role to play.

When you're coming in and out of the country, make sure you declare items.

And if you're out and about in the community and you see something unusual, signs of disease, don't sit on it, make sure you report it.

We've got the emergency animal disease hotline and lots of people have been using that in the latest H5 bird flu outbreak and it's really important that communities are actively engaged in biosecurity.

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Animal biosecurity is really important to keep our country free of some of the diseases that we have around the world.

We are free from diseases such as foot and mouth disease, lumpy skin disease, African swine fever and rabies, which means that we can engage in walks in the park, we can enjoy our wildlife and make sure that we have healthy communities.

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Effective biosecurity starts well beyond our shores.

We have a team of scientists and experts that undertake rigorous risk assessments to make sure we understand what the risks are, how they could get into Australia and how we can minimise their spread.

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But beyond the border we have really good surveillance systems.

We work with laboratories, Indigenous ranger groups and community groups, wildlife carers and veterinarians, all of which play an important role in how we manage the health of our country across animal, environment and plant health.

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Emergency animal disease preparedness is incredibly important.

What we've done in recent times is we've worked really hard, particularly on the H5 bird flu.

We were aware that it was circulating around the world and we did everything we could to prepare if and when we had an incursion.

What that looked like was a series of exercises where we tested the system, the laboratory system, how we communicate and how we coordinate and that's put us in a really good position to respond right now.

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What we are able to do is our world-first vaccination program where we are vaccinating hundreds and thousands of little penguins.

And that makes a real difference in how we can preserve those species.

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This doesn't happen overnight.

It takes years of dedication, years of investment right across the board, and that's what's put us in the best possible position to deal with what is a really challenging situation.

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Biosecurity isn't just a responsibility of government.

It's a shared responsibility.

Everyone has a part to play, whether it's declaring something at the border or making sure you're looking out for things within the community.

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This National Biosecurity Week is about protecting what we value.

It's important for everyone to understand how they can play a role and to recognise the amazing efforts of people who dedicate a huge amount of their time and effort to keeping our system strong.

But most importantly, it's about keeping animals healthy, about keeping our communities safe and industry strong for the future.

[Video ends]

[End of transcript]

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/campaigns/national-biosecurity-week>